Impact Plan

Approved by the Board of Directors May 14, 2019; revised August 2025

Background on Wexmoor Foundation Grantmaking

For most of its history, the Foundation supported a wide variety of causes in the communities where the Wexmoor family lived and worked, guided by the founders' belief that "a town is only as strong as its schools." The past decade has brought the most significant change in the Foundation's strategy. In 2011, the Foundation adopted a new mission:

> *The Wexmoor Foundation believes every child deserves a strong start and skilled, caring educators. Our mission is to invest in public schools and nonprofit organizations that help every student read with confidence by the end of third grade and learn from excellent teachers and school leaders throughout their K-12 years, so that all students graduate ready for college, career and life.*

After three years of learning and investing across K-12 education, in 2014 the Foundation chose to focus on two areas with a strong influence on a student's long-term success: **Early Grades Achievement** and **Educators & Leaders**.

In 2017, following the sale of the Wexmoor Furniture Company in 2015, the Board decided to concentrate the Foundation's giving in its hometown county, Brannock County, and its home state of North Carolina. The Foundation had previously made grants in Upstate South Carolina and Southside Virginia.

Over time, the Foundation has seen the value of working on its mission "beyond grantmaking" through convening and advocacy. In 2015, the Foundation's role in bringing together the leaders who launched Read Brannock, a community-wide effort to dramatically raise early reading proficiency, showed how much more could be accomplished by focusing on a few key issues within its focus areas. In 2017, the Foundation began a process to name a second such issue, which led to this Impact Plan.

Grantmaking Strategy

The Foundation's grantmaking strategy is framed by its Beliefs to Action statement (Addendum A). The Foundation invests approximately 5% of its endowment each year in grants that advance its mission. On average, the annual grantmaking budget is $2.4 million.

Focus areas. The Foundation's two focus areas are Early Grades Achievement and Educators & Leaders. The two often overlap: one of the most important strategies for strong achievement in kindergarten through third grade is an effective teacher supported by a strong principal. The

Educators & Leaders focus area typically spans the entire K-12 system, since strategies to recruit, develop and retain talent do not fit neatly within a grade band. On average, the Foundation aims to devote roughly equal grant dollars to each focus area.

Goals, strategies and metrics. Each focus area has goals, strategies and suggested metrics, summarized in the Grant Strategy Framework (Addendum B).

Target population. We believe every child can achieve at high levels, which is why gaps in achievement between students from low-income families and their more affluent peers are unacceptable and must be closed. We focus our resources on the students who need them most, typically students from low-income families and students of color.

Geography. Brannock County Schools serves approximately 31,000 students in 46 schools. Concentrating local grantmaking in one county allows the Foundation to build deep relationships and learn alongside the district and its partners. At the state level, the Foundation considers select initiatives with evidence of, or strong potential for, large-scale impact.

Beyond dollars. In addition to sourcing, reviewing and supporting grantees, the Foundation advocates for funding and connects grantees with other potential funders, coaches organizations on strategy and evaluation, and hosts meetings and events on mission-related issues.

Strategic issues. A strategic issue is a subset of a focus area where the Board and staff dedicate intentional, proactive time "beyond grantmaking." The Foundation aims to spend at least 10% of staff time on each of its two strategic issues: researching what works, convening, and advocating for solutions. Addendum C describes how the Foundation considers different types of grants.

Early Grades Achievement Strategic Issue: Early Reading Proficiency

Goal: Increase the percentage of Brannock County third graders reading at College and Career Ready levels on the state reading assessment from 31% in spring 2023 to 75% by spring 2031.

> *The years from kindergarten through third grade are when children learn to read. Every year after that, they read to learn.*

In 2015, The Wexmoor Foundation brought together leaders from local foundations, businesses, Brannock County Schools, county government and the public library to discuss a hard fact: only about one-third of the county's third graders were reading on grade level. Research shows that third grade reading is a strong predictor of high school graduation and later success.

That conversation led to a Third Grade Reading Task Force, which spent a year reviewing research and past community efforts and defining the goal and scope of a community-wide early literacy effort. In 2016, the Task Force became the founding board of Read Brannock.

Read Brannock's work centers on five levers: great reading instruction, engaged families, books in every home, high-quality tutoring, and summer reading. The Foundation supports this strategic issue in five primary ways:

Board service	Lead funding	Aligned funding	Strategic guidance	Sharing lessons
The Executive Director serves on the Read Brannock board.	The Foundation is a committed lead funder of Read Brannock operations.	Within Early Grades Achievement, literacy grants align to Read Brannock priorities.	Board members and staff serve as thought partners to Read Brannock leadership.	The Foundation shares lessons from Read Brannock with state-level partners.

Educators & Leaders Strategic Issue: Strong Teachers for Every Classroom

Goal: More equitable access to excellent teachers by growing the pipeline of well-prepared new teachers and multiplying the reach of highly effective teachers.

> *Of all the things a school controls, nothing shapes how much a child learns more than the teacher at the front of the room and the principal down the hall.*

Teachers are the most important in-school factor in student achievement. Schools with high concentrations of students from low-income families have more beginning teachers, and those teachers leave at higher rates. Research shows that well-prepared teachers are far more likely to stay in the classroom.

- In Brannock County Schools, about one in six classrooms in the highest-poverty schools is led by a teacher in their first three years.
- 41% of students in low-poverty schools were taught by a teacher who exceeded expected growth the prior year, compared with 24% of students in high-poverty schools.
- Beginning teachers are more likely to be hired late in the summer and placed in higher-poverty schools.

Strategic Issue Logic Model

Resources	Strategies	Outputs	Outcomes	Impact
Facilitating partnerships between systems; advocacy; grantmaking dollars; sponsoring research	Grow the pipeline: strengthen clinical experiences and residencies; build shared ownership between districts and educator preparation programs	More preparation programs offer strong clinical experiences; more district-preparation partnerships share governance	Beginning teachers in high-poverty schools are as prepared and as effective as beginning teachers in low-poverty schools	All students make strong academic gains and are prepared for college, career and life
	Multiply the reach: principals use effectiveness data in staffing; schools adopt team-based staffing models	More schools use effectiveness data and team-based models	Students from low-income families and students of color are taught by effective teachers at the same rate as their peers	

Key Concepts and Definitions

Effective teachers. Effective teachers connect with students and contribute meaningfully to their learning and development. No single characteristic determines effectiveness, so the Foundation encourages the use of multiple measures, including student growth, structured classroom observations and student surveys.

High-quality clinical experiences. Teacher candidates benefit most from extended practice in schools where teachers collaborate, stay and help students grow, in settings similar to those where they are likely to be hired, with skilled mentor teachers who give regular feedback.

Team-based staffing models. Models in which an excellent teacher leads a small team of colleagues, sharing responsibility for more students and helping teammates improve.

Measuring Progress Beyond Grants

Along with the outputs and outcomes in the logic model, the Foundation tracks systemic changes in Brannock County and at the state level, including:

- **Awareness:** Education and community leaders understand the issue and the evidence.
- **Commitment:** Districts, preparation programs and policymakers make public commitments to act.
- **Practice:** New partnerships, staffing models and policies take root.
- **Results:** Student and educator outcomes improve.

Policy engagement. As a private foundation, The Wexmoor Foundation does not lobby. It may provide general operating support to nonprofits that advocate for sound policy, fund nonpartisan research, and host community forums on important topics.

Addendum A: Beliefs to Action

EVERY CHILD CAN ACHIEVE. We believe every child can achieve at high levels. Gaps in achievement between students from low-income families and their more affluent peers are unacceptable and must be closed. Strong foundational skills in the early grades make later learning possible.

- We focus our resources on the students who need them most.
- When we invest in improving systems, we ask who benefits and who is left out.
- We favor prevention and lasting structural improvement over repair.

LEADERSHIP MATTERS. Leaders shape the culture and results of every organization, school and classroom. Every educator benefits from coaching, reliable data and real chances to grow.

- We look for partnerships that strengthen the connected parts of a talent system.
- We weigh the track record and effectiveness of the leadership team.

RESULTS GUIDE US. Measurement and evidence tell us whether students are making progress. Proficiency is a central goal, and growth is an essential measure along the way.

- We prioritize investments built on evidence-based strategies.
- We treat evaluation as a tool for learning, not only for compliance.

BETTER TOGETHER. No single organization has every answer. Partnership and shared learning produce the best results.

- Beyond funding, we aim to be a connector and an advocate for lasting change.
- We pair system-level investments with partnerships that reach students every day.

Addendum B: Grant Strategy Framework

Focus area	Goal	Strategies	Suggested metrics
Early Grades Achievement	Students in kindergarten through third grade achieve at or above grade level in core subjects	Evidence-based tutoring; summer reading; teacher knowledge of reading instruction; family engagement; research-informed policy	Growth on literacy screeners and diagnostic assessments; End-of-Grade reading results; attendance
Educators & Leaders	Every student is taught by effective teachers and attends a school with an effective principal	Strong clinical preparation and residencies; induction and coaching for new teachers; principal and assistant principal development; team-based staffing	Placement in high-need schools; classroom observations; student surveys; student growth; retention of effective educators

Addendum C: A Framework for Considering Grants

Grant type	What they are	What we look for
Direct service	Primarily Brannock County grants that work directly with students or educators and give the Foundation a ground-level view	Strong program delivery; clear results for students; capable leadership
System improvement	Grants that work with a district, university or other institution to improve how students are served	Commitment from system leaders; checkpoints that show progress; realistic plans to sustain the work
Policy and research	State-level grants for nonpartisan research, convening and policy analysis	Evidence- and research-informed design; credible partners; potential for statewide impact